

Retired EP Educator Follows Tradition

Waide Family Raised On Chisum Trail Ranch

By JESSIE PETERSON
Written Especially for Sundial

Webster Waide spent most of his adult life as an educator 36 years of it in the El Paso school system prior to his retirement in 1961. But born on the Chisum Trail, ranching was always in his blood and when he and his wife retired they bought a ranch in New Mexico and named it The Flying W. Located in Rio Arriba County, it is 75 miles northwest of Santa Fe on the Canones River and only a few miles from the beautiful Abiqui Lake.

Waide's grandfather, James M. Waide, came to Texas from Athens, Tenn. in 1864 and when the educator was a youngster he wanted to be a cowboy and run a large cattle spread just as his grandfather, father and uncles had done all their lives.

"My dreams of becoming a 'cattle-king' were shattered when I was quite a young boy," Waide recalled. "My father realized that education was the answer to a young man's future. The days of the cattle barons in Texas were over."

Waide explained that his grandfather had moved from Tennessee and spent a short time in East Texas before moving on west to Denton County. He rode the famous Chisum Trail with its founder, John Chisum, making cattle drives to Kansas, and discovering that he liked the cattle business.

"My grandfather," explained Waide, "was an educated southern gentleman, often amazing his neighbors with his vast knowledge of things other than cattle. My father, David Harding Waide, and the other James M. Waide children were all well educated even though they would perhaps have preferred to stick with the cattle business. My father saw to it that my two sisters and I were also educated so that we could properly take our places in any environment."

Waide enjoys talking about his family's colorful history, many of the stories coming from his father and his Uncle Joe Waide, who was the last of the James Waide children to die. He spent his entire long life on the Old Chisum Trail Ranch.

BOUGHT CHISUM RANCH IN 1866

"Uncle Joe lived at the home ranch until he died in 1969. Of course the original log house which was there when my grandfather bought the ranch from John Chisum in 1866 was remodeled long before the Waide family grew up. Grandfather had 12 children, six sons and six daughters. That many children required more rooms to be added from time to time. The house is a large frame painted white with gallery across the wide front. In the early days there was an ice-house where meats and vegetables, milk and butter were kept. This boon to the household al-

lowed the womenfolk to set an exceptionally good table, the pride of all true Texas women.

"My grandfather bought the Chisum Ranch when John Chisum's herd outgrew the old spread. My father remembered helping to move the cattle to the new spread in southeastern New Mexico. He was only a boy of 13 at that time. He thought there must have been about ten thousand cattle on this never-to-be-forgotten trailherd drive. The cowboys were a hardy, colorful bunch, and he listened with ears wide open to the tales told around the camp fires. There were other teen-agers on the drive, but older by a few years. Boys in early Texas learned to 'make a hand' at a very early age in those rugged days."

Waide's Uncle Joe always carried on the family tradition of being a good neighbor, and devoted much of his time to civic affairs. When the town of Bolivar, in Denton County near the Chisum Ranch, was presented a plaque honoring the South American liberator for whom the town was named, Uncle Joe was one of the men who greeted the consul general of Venezuela, the consul general of Colombia, the vice consul of Venezuela and Sanger City councilman Keith Pate."

The state of Texas put a historical marker in front of the old Chisum home a few years ago thus making it one of the state's places of interest to all history buffs.

Waide has many interesting old papers that tell colorful stories of the Old Chisum Trail and other interesting bits of early days in Texas. One of these is handwritten record of Indian raids in Denton County. It is written on a parchment-like white paper in very heavy black ink. The time was 1868.

RAISED FINE HORSES

Another interesting bit of history is an official letter from the U.S. Treasury which acknowledges and allows James M. Waide's claim against the government for 65 horses stolen by Indians, and recovered by the government. James Waide not only had a herd of fine cattle; he also raised some of the finest horses in Texas. Indians counted their wealth according to the number of good horses they owned, so the Waide Ranch suffered many raids on their fine horses. The 65 horses that were recovered were just a few of the many losses from Indian raids, and rustlers that roved the wide Texas ranges. The Kiowas and Comanches had gathered a drove of 2,300 horses which the Army recovered from them, and Waide identified his horses by their brands.

"My grandfather put in his claim for the horses at Ft. Sul, Oklahoma, on Oct. 15, 1892. Indian Agent Tatum approved the claim, and Waide received the letter from the government acknowledging a valid claim. A sum of \$3,250 was the acknowledged indebtedness, but to this day the government has never paid this debt, Waide said.

Waide remembers both his father and his Uncle Joe telling stories about Indian raids, and skirmishes the white people had with them from time to time. One of the most costly encounters, and one which, according to Waide's father, should never have happened, was the Dove Creek battle between the Kickapoo Indians, a company of Confederate soldiers, and a group of cattlemen and cowboys. At that time, Jan. 8, 1865, all of the country west of Denton County, Wise and Tarrant Counties was the domain of Indians, buffaloes and the vanguard of adventurous white men.

"My grandfather and a number of his friends had a call from Gov. James W. Throckmorton for help in running down a tribe of Indians said to be on the warpath. The governor had ordered the militia and a company of Confederate soldiers to take the trail after the Indians."

Col. Barry was in charge of Ft. Belknap when the call for help came. Thirty of his men under the command of Lt. J. R. Giddian left the fort and James M. Waide and a band of his friends, heavily armed and well mounted, joined him.

WAIT SIX DAYS, MOVE ON

"My grandfather's friends and the soldiers reached the vicinity where this group were to meet the Confederate soldiers after two days hard riding. All along the way they had found where the Indians had camped, leaving carcasses of buffalo. Grandfather, after examining a carcass, discovered that the animal had been killed with a high-powered rifle. He advised young Lt. Giddian to go slowly as these Indians were well armed. He also pointed out that their making camp as often as they had seemed



THE FLYING W — When Mr. and Mrs. Webster Waide retired from El Paso Public Schools they purchased a New Mexico ranch in Rio Arriba County, 75 miles northwest of Santa Fe on the Canones River and near Abiqui Lake.

to prove that they were in no hurry and were not a war party."

The cattlemen and Lt. Giddian's soldiers waited six days, then growing impatient at their inactivity, they decided to move on. They came upon the Indians camped at Dove Creek, a tributary of the South Concho. Again James Waide pointed out the fact that this large number of wigwams indicated that this was a peaceful tribe of Indians. They had chosen a very strategic spot for their camp, in a curve of the river and well sheltered by a dense thicket.

"The State militia had joined the Confederate soldiers. They were ordered to go in one direction around the Indians and my grandfather's group were ordered to circle in the opposite direction. This proved very poor strategy. Those friends of my grandfather's and the soldiers of Lt. Giddian's group found the bullets coming at them from all directions. Horses were being hit and were screaming in pain and fright, men were falling from the backs of rearing horses. Lt. Giddian's mount was shot from beneath him just as a bullet hit him. He was thrown from the horse and a soldier went to his aid. Several of the cattlemen were wounded, none of them killed, but several soldiers were dead. Lt. Giddian was severely wounded, as were several others, among his troops.

"I. D. Ferguson, a friend of my grandfather's, had captured a young Indian boy the day before the battle and this boy had told Ferguson that there were 1,400 Kickapoo Indians, men, women and children in this band. They were on their way to Mexico. If this boy's story had been told the commanders of the two groups, and believed, many lives could have been saved.

"My grandfather began the task of rounding up his friends, and helping with bandaging wounds, where skilled medical aid wasn't needed. Many horses had been killed, or throwing their riders had dashed away, so men had either to ride double or walk. Walking in highheeled cowboy boots was very uncomfortable, so although many of the horses bucked a little at a double burden, it was better than walking.

"The first night's camp was made early the next (Please Turn To Page 3)



CLAIM GRANTED — A claim by James A. Waide for 65 horses stolen by the Indians and recovered by the government was allowed and an award of \$3,250 less \$400 for attorney's fees was granted in 1892. However, according to Webster Waide the claim has never been paid.

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COVER PHOTO — Abiqui Lake in northern New Mexico is one of the beauty spots near The Flying W Ranch northwest of Santa Fe.